
A DATA STUDY

Inside the Bootstrapped Economy

What 1,000 indie startups reveal about revenue, growth, and category economics

TRUSTMRR DATASET · 1,000 STARTUPS · FROZEN 30 JUL 2026

THE STATE OF THE MARKET

A dataset built on extremes

1,000 startups, \$133.8M in combined trailing revenue, and a market where a handful of outliers skew everything.

REVENUE DISTRIBUTION

\$282

MEDIAN MRR

Half of all startups earn less than this per month

47.8x

MEAN-TO-MEDIAN GAP

Mean MRR of \$13.5K, inflated by a small set of big earners

\$25.0M

TOP 12-MONTH REVENUE

Highest-earning single startup in the dataset

DATASET COVERAGE & QUALITY

29

CATEGORIES

From AI to Education to Marketplace tools

65

COUNTRIES REPRESENTED

Startups span 76% of rows with disclosed geography

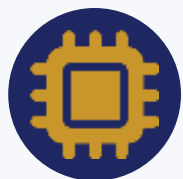
13%

ANONYMIZED LISTINGS

Stealth-mode startups with partial data disclosed

THE CATEGORY PARADOX

Crowded categories aren't the ones making money



MOST CROWDED CATEGORY

AI

~20% of all startups, mid-pack revenue

Median MRR of just ~\$446 — heavy competition hasn't translated into standout monetization.



SMALLER, SHARPER NICHES

3-40x

higher median MRR than AI

Education, Marketing, and Analytics carry far fewer entrants but monetize dramatically better.

Productivity, despite decent volume, ranks lowest of all categories on median revenue.

WHAT ACTUALLY DRIVES REVENUE

Three signals that consistently predict MRR



0.91

Correlation: subscriptions → MRR

Active subscriber count is the strongest single predictor of revenue in the dataset.



2,500x

Top vs. bottom domain-authority tier

Startups with high SEO domain rating earn dramatically more than unranked sites.



6x

B2B vs. B2C median MRR

B2B products monetize far better per customer than consumer-facing ones.

By contrast, social following shows almost no relationship with revenue ($r = 0.02$).

Businesses for sale look different from ones still growing



STILL OPERATING

Flat

median 30-day MRR growth

A split market: small startups posting explosive % growth off a tiny base, alongside established businesses in sharp decline.



LISTED FOR SALE

~2.3x

median asking price vs. trailing revenue

For-sale listings carry higher MRR but noticeably slower growth — sellers tend to list plateaued businesses, not high-growth ones.

Where startups are based — and how they get paid

GEOGRAPHY



UNITED STATES

258

startups — highest volume AND quality

Leads on both count and median MRR among countries with meaningful sample size.



INDIA

\$6

median MRR vs. \$2,655 mean

A huge mean/median gap — mostly early-stage listings, skewed by a couple of outliers.

PAYMENT INFRASTRUCTURE



PAYMENT RAILS

Stripe

correlates with company maturity

Stripe-only startups show the highest mean MRR; newer processors skew toward earlier-stage companies.

WHAT THIS MEANS

Four takeaways from the data

01

Focus beats hype

Niche categories and B2B businesses outmonetize crowded, buzzy ones like AI.

02

Revenue leaves fingerprints

Subscriptions and domain authority predict MRR; social following doesn't.

03

Medians tell the real story

A handful of outsized winners distort every average in this dataset.

04

For sale $\neq$ high growth

Read the growth trajectory, not just current MRR, before paying a multiple.